

Recognize it

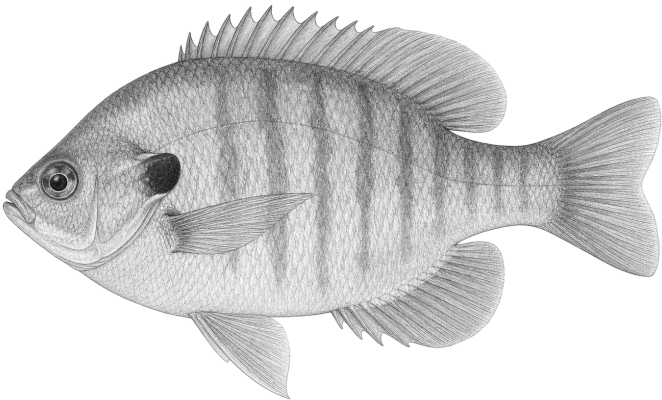
Deep sunfish with a dark flexible ear flap and a blue-black cheek edge.

Body	Compressed oval body; faint bars; breeding males darken at breast.
Mouth/fins	Small mouth; long pointed pectoral fin; continuous spiny dorsal.
Confusion	Pumpkinseed has orange/red on the ear flap and wavy cheek lines.

Lake role

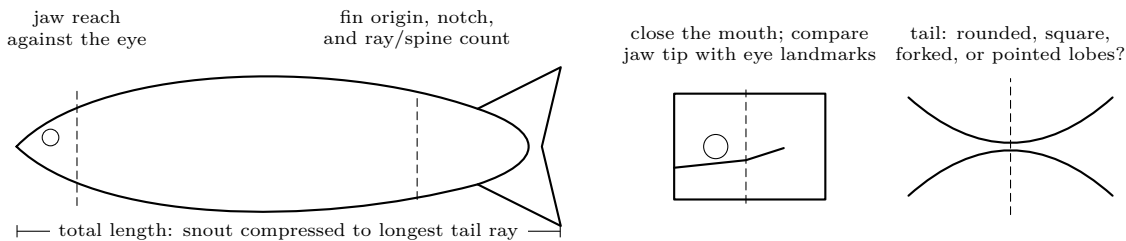
Where it belongs Vegetation, docks, wood, and firm-bottom nesting colonies.
Food and season Aquatic insects and small prey; shallow in warm spawning periods, edge-oriented later.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Read the fish before naming it



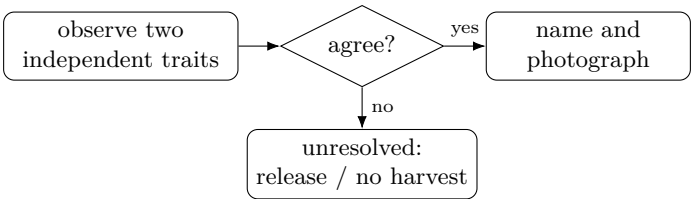
- Silhouette first.** Confirm the deep oval body, small mouth, and long pointed pectoral fin.
- Hard structure second.** Inspect the flexible ear flap and the joined spiny-to-soft dorsal fin.
- Markings last.** Use the plain dark flap and faint bars; breeding darkness alone is not diagnostic.

Intermediate questions

Before looking at the species name, answer aloud: *Where does the closed jaw end? Are dorsal sections joined or separate? What is the tail-lobe shape? Which mark is structural enough to survive poor light?* If two answers conflict, record “unresolved” and do not force the identification.

Confusion-pair gate

Candidate	Bluegill
Nearest alternative	Pumpkinseed has orange/red on the ear flap and wavy cheek lines.
Required gate	A bluegill must lack the pumpkinseed’s orange/red flap margin and show the longer pointed pectoral.
Independent check	Fold the pectoral forward without damage; its pointed tip and plain dark flap must agree.



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test inside weed pockets early, then deep outside weedline and suspended insect layers.
North	Test protected weed bays, docks where access is lawful, and the outside coontail edge.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Field evidence log

Date/time	Water + station	Depth/temp	Two observed traits	Habitat, lure, result
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Evidence threshold. One sighting is an observation, not an abundance claim. Repeat the same identification gate on another fish, retain a clear lateral photograph when lawful and safe, and note failed searches as carefully as catches. Record nest guarding separately from feeding fish; nest catches bias size and sex observations.

Presentations

1. **Float and tiny jig.** Use a small hook or jig with worm segment; set depth so bait stays above weed tops.
2. **Vertical micro-jig.** Drop beside deep weeds and watch line for lift bites.
3. **Stop rule.** Downsize only after fish are seen; move when small fish dominate and the goal is a modest meal of adults.

On-water verification

After the first response, ask: *Did the fish, depth, cover, and bite match the prediction?* Repeat once. If the second result disagrees, return to search mode rather than explaining away the evidence.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Wet hands, cradle the body, and fold the dorsal spines flat from front to back.

Harvest decision · 2026–27

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Keep a modest number of mid-size adults; release exceptional males and stop at the meal plan.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin's Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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